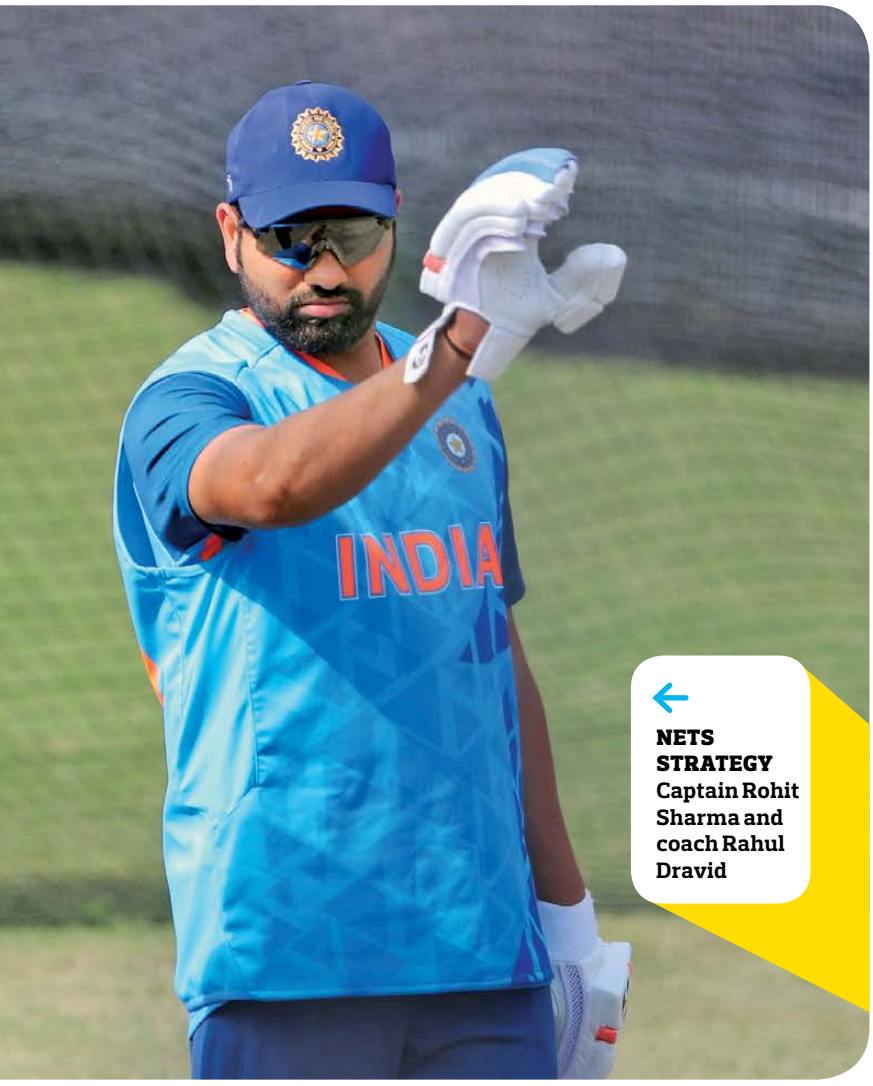


NETS STRATEGY Captain Rohit Sharma and coach Rahul Dravid

riches that have come with corporate support: last year's IPL sensation Rinku Singh will probably earn more in a season playing for his franchise than Kapil Dev's entire India career payout.

The best cricketers are typically adjusting their talents to this gilded age: Indian cricket is now routinely throwing up top-class players who hit the ball harder and further than their predecessors (albeit armed with much better bats) and skillful bowlers who have mastered a far greater variety of deliveries, especially in the crucial death overs. Watching a Shubman Gill—the gen-next batting champion—smash fast bowlers for six after having leant into a gorgeous on drive the previous ball or a Jasprit Bumrah bowl a well-disguised slower delivery after having just delivered a rapid bouncer is to celebrate the genius of players with extraordinary skill sets. Not to forget a potential game-changer in Kuldeep Yadav, who is an old-style spinning sorcerer slowly perfecting one of cricket's most difficult art forms: left-arm wrist spin.

Importantly, the sport is far more 'democratised' and aspirational than ever before: the players who will represent the country in the World Cup come from amazingly diverse backgrounds. The meteoric rise of a Mohammed Siraj, son of an autorickshaw driver, from playing tennis ball cricket on the streets of old Hyderabad to now being a much-feared new ball bowler, is the great Indian cricket dream to cherish. As is that of his fast-bowling senior, Mohammed Shami, who played his early cricket in a remote UP village. When the teams line up, a commerce graduate, K.L. Rahul, will stand alongside a class nine dropout in Hardik Pandya: the only qualification on the cricket field is merit, not lineage. The cash-rich Indian cricket board may still be run by an opaque, unaccountable clique of politically well-connected VIPs, but the sport itself is a joyous reflection of an 'equal opportunities' society.

So, will this impressively assembled 'new India' team win the 2023 World Cup? It most certainly can. But winning a global tournament can be a matter of fine margins: recall the enthralling last World Cup final which was won on a peculiar boundary count-back rule. Both England and New Zealand were tied on scores, but England won it after a super-over because they had hit more boundaries. The sport is also more competitive than ever before: every team in this World Cup, with the possible exception of the Netherlands, will go into every game in this tournament believing they can win. Teams like Australia, England and Pakistan are brimming with match-winning players, while even a plucky Afghanistan could come charging down the Khyber Pass to pull off a surprise or two.

But here is the good news: the last three World Cups have been won by the host nations. If Rohit Sharma and his men in blue can handle the pressure of massive expectations, there is no reason why we can't have another incandescent night on finals day on November 19, this time at the Narendra Modi stadium in Ahmedabad. After the luminosity of Chandrayaan and the buzz of a G20 summit, a World Cup win at a stadium named after the prime minister might give even more momentum to the BJP's 'Rising India' drumbeat ahead of the general election. But for the next few weeks at least, bruising political propaganda battles can wait as the cricketers take centre stage. A carnival of cricket awaits us. Enjoy the spectacle. ■

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